2.5 Minute Ride

By Lisa Kron

INTRODUCTION

You know that sound . . . the clack, clack, clack of the wheels on the track as the roller coaster inches you toward the first drop. That sound builds suspense -- builds anxiety -- until all of a sudden, you're at the top and facing your ultimate demise at the bottom of the first drop. At least with roller coasters you know the ride won't be very long and the likelihood of surviving the experience is very high. Now imagine you hear that same sound again, but this time you aren't at an amusement park . . . The year is 1937. The track is for an overcrowded train car and the clack, clack, clack is bringing you closer and closer to Auschwitz. This time it's not a . . .

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The sound of a slide projector advancing to the next slide, a woman holding a clicker describes the "slides" (just squares of colored light, not actual pictures) She describes what she sees.

LISA: *(Changes slide)* **(Pg 5)** These are my father's parents. I never knew them actually. My father left his hometown in Germany in 1937, by himself, when he was fifteen years old, as a part of a program to get all the Jewish children out of Germany. I'm making a videotape about my father – about his experiences – well, actually about this trip we took together to his hometown and then to Auschwitz.

(Changes slide) **(Pg 6-7)** This is my father and his father in the synagogue where his father was the teacher in the Jewish school. This was taken a few days before my dad left Germany to come to the United States. When he came here, he lived with a foster family in Connecticut and received letters from his parents about once a week, until one week, instead, he received a letter from the Red Cross informing him that his parents had been deported to the Litzmannstadt Ghetto in Poland. That was the last time he heard from them.

(Changes slide) This is a letter my father received in 1947 from a man who had been with his parents in the Ghetto. I had it translated and it says, "Unfortunately, I must inform you that your parents were among the first transports sent to Auschwitz." So, the other part of

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this trip was Auschwitz where neither of us had ever been before. The trip was so much more than either of us had imagined and when I returned I decided to make this video. My father has so many incredible stories – I wanted to make a record.

(Changes slide) **(Pg 8)** This is Lansing, Michigan where I grew up, where my parents still live. [I went back home] to shoot some interviews with my dad, and then also to accompany my entire family on our annual trip to the Cedar Pointe Amusement Park in Ohio, where my dad loves to ride the roller coasters. [I] wanted to get that on tape as well. **(Pg 11)** At the entrance to the Magnum there are signs which say under no circumstances is this ride suitable for people who are elderly, diabetic or have heart conditions. My father can't read the signs because, in addition to having all the conditions listed, he is also legally blind. I tell him what it says. *(to dad)* Are you sure this is a good idea?

DAD: I don't have to do anything. All I have to do is sit there.

LISA: *(Changes slide, laughs)* **(Pg 18-19)** Cedar Point has more roller coasters than any other amusement park in America – and every year they add a new one. Here you can see me and my dad standing in front of the Demon Drop which is a three-story free fall. Dad asked and asked and asked about it. All of a sudden it dawned on me. *(to dad)* Do you want to ride the Demon Drop?

DAD: Oh. Well, if that's what would make you happy.

LISA: It's hard . . . it's hard to describe a three-story free fall. It's not bad, really. It's not good. It's just like – *(a sudden shocked exhalation of all the air in her lungs, as if kicked in the stomach)* When it was over, I was speechless, I was aghast. I looked at my dad. He was grinning. A crazy sort of a grin.

(Pg 19-20) [And now we're] in Poland. I don't speak Polish. I don't speak German either. One time we stop to ask a man for directions and when he answers me I start to laugh. Right in his face. How absurd it is that I'm listening to him as if I had the vaguest idea what he is saying. He says something like, "Blah, blah, blah. Pointy, pointy, point. Polish, Polish, Polish, Polish . . " In the direction of Auschwitz. **(Pg 22)** What month was it? October. So cold.

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Dad and I, we've been waiting for this our whole lives. We don't know how to feel. Tomorrow we'll be at the place where his parent's bodies lie. No, they were burned. Will we step on their ashes? Will we see a wooden pallet where they slept? Will they be hovering above the place, watching us? Have they waited all this time for their little boy to come and say good-bye to them? **(Pg 23-24)** What will I do, I thought, if my father cries? I've never seen him cry.

(Changes slide) **(Pg 24)** We go on the Mean Streak, a new wooden roller coaster with a 2.5 minute ride. And as soon as we take off, I know that it's a mistake. Dad is clinging to the bar and he has a look on his face like a horse in a fire. I think, Oh my dear God, what have I done? This is really going to kill him. 2.5 minutes is a really long time on a roller coaster if you are having a good time. If you think the experience is killing your father it's a really, really long time. For a split second I can see [the headlines] Bizarre Murder! [Daughter] Forces Blind Holocaust Victim on Roller Coaster! I'm so relieved when we get to the end, I want to carry him to the first-aid station. He stumbles out of the car. Walks right up to the video camera, as if for a post-game interview, and says, "That one was the best!" And then he asks me if I want to go again.

(Changes slide) We read every word of every exhibit. I have to read them out loud to Dad, of course. *(to Dad)* Okay. This is a poem by a woman named Zofia Grocho-o-wal-ska Abromowicz. It says:

1944.
Wheels speed along the tracks
rushing toward the victory of crime,
transporting, transporting people to gas,
people to a cremator,
people to a petrol sprayed pyre.
Smoke floats, thick, foul smoke . . .

(Seeing the next line, her face crumples. A sob comes out. She turns and overs her face)

(to audience) I bury my head in my father's shoulder. He pats my back. He's okay. He's a good dad. I feel shaky and helpless, but pull myself together. *(turns back to the poem)*

People burn people here.

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(Changes slide) **(Pg 25-28)** In the afternoon we drive three miles to the second camp – Birkenau. Here there is no sun. This is malevolent ground. They give us a map and we go exploring. The day alternates between a feeling of horror and a feeling we're at Disney. We look at the map and say, "Well, where should we go next? To the pits where they buried bodies in mass graves or the fields where they piled them up and burned them." We have to laugh. Especially at the bookstores which we refer to as the Auschwitz gift shop. We make gruesome jokes about what gifts they might sell . . . lamp shades and soap. I actually go into one of the shops to buy a book but it's full of pictures and I walk out. *(a long sill pause – an almost unbearable silence as she realizes the thing she's about to say)* I'd been so afraid I wouldn't feel anything here. (the *silence hangs as she realizes)* I think that was my biggest fear.

(Changes slide) You already know what this looks like, right? *(Changes slide)* You've seen these images before. *(Changes slide)* You don't need me to describe this to you. *(Changes slide)* Even if you've never been there, you've seen the History Channel . . . Sophie's Choice . . . Shindler's List! *(Changes slide)* You know what? That's exactly what it looks like. The films from the liberation of the camps with the bulldozers and the bodies. Right? *(Changes slide)* You all know what this looks like.

I feel like I'm evading the issue here, but I don't know what the issue is. Yes! Yes! I wanted to tell you about our trip. No. No! That's not my point! I wanted to tell you about my father! *(pause, stunned at her own revelation. She has no idea what to say next. This should be a truly horrible moment- she drops the clicker)* But . . . I don't know. I really don't know. He's . . . a guy . . . You know, he's an ordinary guy. He's my dad. *(she speaks softly and intently, needing to make a connection so the audience hears and understands what she is about to say)*

Do you know what he told us when we were growing up? He told us many times, "If it weren't for the good fortune of being born a Jew I might have become a Nazi." And then he'd tell us this story: he'd gone to school with a boy named Lohmann who was the only

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other boy in his class who didn't wear a Hitler youth uniform. My father wasn't allowed to wear one, of course, because he was a Jew, and he was beaten by the other boys for that, but Lohmann didn't wear one because he refused. "I often wonder," my father would tell us, "I often wonder.

If I had had the opportunity to wear that uniform if I would have had the ***courage of Lohmann***? I'm lucky to be a Jew so I didn't have to ***make that choice."*** *(stops herself, suddenly realizing she has gone too far and her intensity has become overwhelming)* Aahh. I can't tell you his stories. I don't have any filter for them. I can hear the myth and the awe creep into my voice. I keep inhaling and I don't exhale, something like that. You should go to Lansing and meet him. He'll cook you dinner! I am so not kidding. *(laughing through tears)*

(Pg 37-38) I have a checklist in my head: things I have to do before my father dies. Number one: look him in the eye and tell him that I love him. Check. Number two: go with him to see the place where his parents were killed. Check. Number three: make this video about his life.

Taping him in his study, at his office, in the park. I've been trying to look at the videotape. It's excruciating. He's lived in Michigan for forty years. He eats in front of the TV. He takes a fitness class at the community college. His life in Lansing doesn't quite match up. The edges are blurred. Then we go to Germany and my father was home. He's in focus here, I thought. He's in context. *(picks up clicker) (Changes slide)* My father is a small man. He smells like lavender. He wears a suit.

(Pg 39) When I was in college I was taught that if you are standing near a piece of furniture on stage you should put you hand on it be cause that will make you look bigger. Well, [that's what I'm doing] . . . I'm putting my hand on my father's life.

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SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

2002 National Qualifier
2008 National Qualifier
2009 National Qualifier
2013 National Qualifier
2014 National Qualifier
2021 National Qualifier – MS
CO State Qualifier
IL State Qualifier

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